

Lesson 18

① ～がたい

Hard to... / Difficult to... / Almost impossible to...

Used when something is **emotionally, mentally, or morally difficult to do or accept**.

It does **not** usually mean that something is difficult because of lack of ability or skill.

“I simply cannot bring myself to / it is very difficult to...”

It is **not used for something you cannot do because you lack the ability**.

It is mainly used with verbs involving **thought, judgment or emotion**, such as 想像する, 理解する, 信じる, and verbs of expression such as 言う and 表す.

So:

信じがたい → **hard to believe** ✓

理解しがたい → **hard to understand/accept** ✓

歩きがたい → generally not used simply to mean **physically difficult to walk**.

例：

1. 彼の行動は理解しがたい。
2. この事故は忘れがたい出来事だった。
3. 彼が犯人だとは信じがたい。

② ～わけにはいかない・～わけにもいかない

Cannot / Can't possibly / Cannot allow oneself to...

Used when something is **possible physically**, but the person **cannot do it because of social expectations, responsibility, morality, circumstances, etc.**

“I could do it, but considering the circumstances, I simply can't.”

例：

1. 明日は試験があるので、今夜遊びに行くわけにはいかない。

2. 大事な会議があるから、会社を休むわけにはいかない。
3. 約束したからには、途中でやめるわけにはいかない。

③ ～かねる

Cannot / Unable to / I'm afraid I cannot...

Used when the speaker **cannot do something because of their position, circumstances, policy, judgment, etc.**

It is often used to **politely and formally refuse** a request.

Nuance: **"I understand, but given the circumstances, I'm afraid I cannot..."**

It is **not used for inability due to lack of skill or physical ability**. It is commonly used when **politely refusing something**, especially in formal or business situations.

例：

1. 申し訳ありませんが、その質問にはお答えしかねます。
2. その意見には賛成しかねます。
3. 残念ながら、ご希望には応じかねます。

Special: ～かねる vs ～かねない

～かねる → **cannot / difficult to do**

その要求は受け入れかねます。

I'm afraid I cannot accept that request.

～かねない → **might / could possibly happen**, usually something negative.

このままでは事故が起こりかねない。

If things continue like this, an accident could occur.

④ ～ようがない

There is no way to... / It is impossible to...

Used when someone wants to do something, but **there is absolutely no method or means to do it**, or when something is logically impossible.

“Even if I wanted to, there is simply no way to do it.”

It can mean:

There is absolutely no method/way to do X.

知らせようがない → **There is no way to inform him.**

It strongly emphasizes **impossibility**.

例：

1. 住所も電話番号も知らないので、連絡しようがない。
2. 証拠がないので、確かめようがない。
3. あんなに壊れていては、直しようがない。

⑤ ～どころではない

Not in a position to... / This is no time for... / Far from being able to...

Used when circumstances make it **impossible to do, enjoy, or even think about something**.

“Given the situation, X is completely out of the question.”

Because of circumstances that leave **no time, money, energy, opportunity, or mental space**, something that would normally be expected or desired is completely impossible.

It emphasizes: **“I’m in no situation to even think about X.”**

例：

1. 仕事が忙しすぎて、休むどころではない。
2. 試験が明日なので、遊んでいるどころではない。
3. 風邪がひどくて、旅行どころではなかった。

⑥ ～得る（～える／～うる）・～得ない（～えない）

～得る = can / may / be possible to ~

Expresses that something is **possible or can happen**.

～得ない = cannot / is impossible to ~

It is difficult to use this for **a particular person's everyday ability or possibility based on a particular situation**.

Nuance:

～得る is about **general possibility**, not someone's personal ability.

例：

1. 事故はいつでも起こり得るので、気をつけてください。
2. この不況では大手企業の倒産もあり得る。
3. 地震がいつ来るかなんて、予測し得ないことだ。
4. 機械は完全には^{じんりき}人力に代わり得ない。